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Arsenal lost the Champions League final on penalties to Paris Saint-Germain as Mikel Arteta sacrificed two key players in defeat.

There was method in the Arsenal madness but ultimately their two lowest possession averages this season coming in losing finals suggests a necessary change for Arteta.

PSG were far from brilliant, but did enough to keep within the finest of margins.

1) Not sure Gabriel Magalhaes should be your fifth penalty taker in a sudden-death scenario Champions League final shoot-out, but equally those generational centre-half partnership comparisons with John Terry and Roberto Carvalho [do benefit from some symmetry](#).

Congratulations, then, to the Brazilian for his European Cup winner's medal in four year's time, suspended but donned in a full kit as Arsenal terrorise their way to an exorcising victory at a final hurdle they currently seem destined to never cross.

2) [Arsenal](#) will at least be accustomed to putting in such attritional Champions League final performances by 2030.

Mikel Arteta urged them to "own" this game but the majority of the second half onwards belonged to back-to-back European champions Paris Saint-Germain. The Gunners had a single shot between the 46th and 118th minutes; it was blocked. PSG had 15 efforts of their own in that time, including the equaliser to Kai Havertz's early opener.

Arsenal had the lowest possession average by a Champions League finalist on record. Their two lowest possession averages across this 63-game season have come in [the Carabao Cup final against a transitional Manchester City](#) and the Champions League final against an excellent PSG who nevertheless looked vulnerable.

The likelihood is Arsenal will reach this stage again. The evidence suggests Arteta needs to change up his approach at least slightly if and when they do. Having leaned so heavily on [a brilliant cup win to achieve buy-in at the start of this journey](#), the Gunners have become Premier League specialists who cannot quite cross the last knockout line.

3) Having said that, Arsenal almost rode those fine margins to glory. They were a couple of decent spot kicks – stuttering run-ups and all – from this being characterised as a campaign-defining defensive masterclass. Or derided as a stain on the sport, with a state-backed sportswashing superclub the awkwardly cast protagonists. Definitely nowhere in between.

The only way through that PSG found was from the penalty spot. That they did so five times was the killer. Arsenal had not conceded one throughout their entire successful Premier League season, so perhaps it was little surprise that they seemed far less stable and sure of themselves in that stretch of the game than the previous 120 minutes.

4) It is a phenomenal credit to PSG and Luis Enrique to have emerged from the experience as only the second team to retain the Champions League crown, and third in European Cup history to combine that trophy with their own league title in successive seasons.

The difference between the 2025 and 2026 finals sums up their uniquely tremendous adaptability. They only had two more shots in their 5-0 demolition of Inter 12 months ago, in which they led comfortably from the 12th minute onwards. Here, they had to chase the match from the sixth minute all the way to a bitter, beautiful, battered and bruised end.

“They are strong physically, they know how to defend and it was very tough,” [Luis Enrique said of the beaten finalists](#). Having won his previous two Champions League finals by an aggregate score of 8-1, he triumphed in a war of endurance for his third.

5) Luis Enrique ought to be [insulted by frequent mentions in the same conversation as this iteration of Liverpool](#). In no world does he leave this for that.

6) Arteta, often portrayed as a sore loser who cannot take his medicine, declared PSG “the best team in the world” after the game, adding his congratulations to them and Luis Enrique.

The caricature many have built up of Arsenal and Arteta in their minds has needed updating for years. Even when thrown the softball of refereeing calls in an officiating display that achieved the holy grail of convincing both sets of supporters they were the victims of a grand conspiracy, the manager pretty much sidestepped them and focused on his players channelling their “pain”.

7) They did so in the Premier League after three consecutive runners-up finishes. Perhaps this is simply a natural part of their Champions League evolution that has seen them lose in the quarter-final, semi-final and final in consecutive seasons.

It would be a little too on the nose for Arteta and his processes and phases to claim the crown next campaign, but not outside the realms of possibility.

As Arteta stressed after the game, this is not a stage Arsenal are particularly familiar with. But with his guidance and these foundations, there will not be another 20-year wait for a final. They are one of the two best teams in the world; it is their grave misfortune that they happened to meet the other here.

8) But they did lead, and for the first half were in control. A deflected Marquinhos clearance let Kai Havertz in down the left-hand side and the first shot of the final was converted with an absurd degree of plumb into the roof of the net from a slight angle.

There was no slalom between defenders as Havertz had a free run from the halfway line against a PSG system not set up to defend, while Matvey Safonov decided to root himself to the line rather than test the structural integrity of his spine like a '99 David Seaman.

The result was nevertheless precisely as emphatic. It was a stunning finish from only the fourth player in European Cup history to score goals in finals for two different clubs, and immediately vindicated Arteta’s call to start the polarising German over Viktor Gyokeres.

9) The problem was that Arsenal, if anything, for me, scored too early. Havertz’s sixth-minute goal doubling up as their last shot on target of the entire game summed up the approach deployed thereafter.

There was method to what only seems like madness in retrospect. The team with the best defence and structure in the world had secured a one-goal lead to protect. 1-0 to the Arsenal had been the

backing track to their successful Premier League run-in, the scoreline by which they won four of their final nine games, and even the way they reached this final by outlasting Atletico Madrid.

1-0 Havertz was literally the decisive match in terms of clinching the title. But that required one half of holding off the resistible force of Burnley; this strategy demanded near-perfection for at least an hour and a half against PSG.

And to reiterate: it almost worked. PSG created nothing in a first half encapsulated by their final three shots all coming from outside the area at either obtuse angles or onerous distances forced by phenomenal off-the-ball movement and an elite deep block.

Arteta would not have scripted the game any differently by that point if given the chance.

10) He might have let Arsenal take the corner they were given in stoppage time actually. Referee Daniel Siebert instead deemed their apparently protracted routine setup not important enough to override the initial six additional minutes, despite an expectant Bukayo Saka having placed the ball in the quadrant.

It would have been Arsenal's first corner; that came in the second minute of extra-time instead, and was hammered into the side netting by Noni Madueke. They ended with four to PSG's 11, and might rue that difference more than any other.

11) The first sign that PSG had identified the need to try something different came with their kick-off to start the second half. Vitinha playing it back rather than thumping it into touch deep in the Arsenal half was telling.

A couple of minutes later, Cristhian Mosquera was booked for time-wasting at a throw-in. His shift up against Khvicha Kvaratskhelia until then had been admirable, but it might have just given the Georgian a slight advantage that he used to turn the momentum of the game entirely.

12) In truth, Mosquera probably wouldn't have defended any differently when Kvaratskhelia and the otherwise anonymous Ousmane Dembele linked up on the edge of the area. A sublime give-and-go finally revealed a crack in the Arsenal armour which Kvaratskhelia capitalised on.

A penalty was almost inevitable from the point Mosquera was made to defend both the Kvaratskhelia pass into Dembele, and the PSG forward's subsequent run into the box. It was a young player out of his natural position being caught on the wrong side and slightly flat-footed, the one time an Arsenal defender had been properly isolated.

Any Arsenal defeat was likely to be defined and dictated by their right-back situation; Mosquera fared well but one lapse let PSG in. That he was instantly brought off for Jurrien Timber once Dembele dispatched the penalty was inevitable.

13) It was also one of the few times Saka wasn't back to help Mosquera out. The closest teammate was Declan Rice, who tracked neither Kvaratskhelia nor Dembele effectively enough.

Saka completed four passes in 82 minutes before being substituted, such was his sacrifice in helping double up on the opposition left-winger rather than being given the platform to thrive in his own right.

Martin Odegaard only made six passes in his hour on the pitch, managing more tackles (two) than shots or chances created combined (one).

For established leaders supposed to provide impetus and technical security, that is stark and calls into question whether this was really the best way to use them.

Both would have taken a penalty in the shoot-out had they lasted the full 120; they might have had to get a proper feel of the ball first, though.

14) But then no PSG player really excelled. Vitinha, Joao Neves and Fabian Ruiz had a ludicrous amount of the ball and did little with it. Kvaratskhelia and Dembele flourished in that decisive moment but were otherwise fitful. Willian Pacho and Marquinhos were decent but both partially responsible for Havertz's goal.

Vitinha was named man of the match. In winning both the coin toss to have the penalties taken at the PSG end and for the French side to go first, it was probably Achraf Hakimi who made the most telling on-pitch contribution.

15) From the 75th minute onwards, an end-to-end game broke out from the exhaustion and anxiety.

Kvaratskhelia's effort was deflected onto the post by Myles Lewis-Skelly after William Saliba had been beaten. David Raya raced off his line to thwart Bradley Barcola as he, too, advanced down that vulnerable right-hand side. Arsenal nearly scored from a long throw. Gabriel Martinelli wasted a counter-attack from a mis-hit Nuno Mendes clearance. Vitinha hit the top of the net after a great run from Desire Doue, who should have done better with a couple of opportunities of his own. Madueke had a borderline penalty shout turned down. Gyokeres fashioned some shooting space on the edge of the area to win what felt like the most narrative-laden corner in history in the 120th minute.

Piero Hincapie was defending on one leg throughout, because who's going to stop him?

It was an uncharacteristic chaos that a tired Arsenal seemed to embrace. That carried through into a shoot-out in which only their keeper saved a penalty and yet they still lost.

16) [Arteta said only that Gabriel, exceptional and the final's best player, "wanted to take number five"](#). It was the first penalty he had ever taken for Arsenal, and might well be the last.

Eberechi Eze had not played well in his cameo but his career penalty record was respectable; that stutter and miss will be the one everyone remembers.

Even Raya, Arsenal's outstanding player this season, seemed overcome with nerves as he dived several seconds before Beraldo took PSG's fifth kick.

For a club so meticulous in its planning and preparation that it has seemingly mastered the art of reducing games to dead-ball situations which can be practiced and rehearsed to the extent they become automatic, to be betrayed by the most basic set-piece of all was the ultimate irony.

That was inevitable with the stakes involved. But at the final hurdle, Arsenal let their emotions take over and it cost them.

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